Haligric Research Integration Series

Grandmother Ocean and the Basket World

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of the Chumash, Pomo, Miwok, and Related California Nations

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Before European contact, California held more linguistic and cultural diversity than almost anywhere else on the continent — hundreds of small, densely settled nations, from the Chumash of the Santa Barbara coast to the Pomo, Miwok, Maidu, and Patwin of the north-central valleys, each with its own language and its own version of a shared ceremonial world.

That world was built underground, in roundhouses where masked dancers renewed the balance of nature itself, and it was woven, literally, into baskets so fine some could hold water.

This is the world of Sky Coyote and the Sun who watches all human affairs, of a secret society whose members alone could interpret the rock art still visible on mountain walls.

It is also the site of one of the most severe and least acknowledged genocides in American history — and, as of November 2024, the first Indigenous-led marine sanctuary the United States has ever designated.

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Introduction — Grandmother Ocean and the Basket World

At the time of European contact, California held one of the highest concentrations of distinct Indigenous languages and nations anywhere in North America — well over a hundred mutually unintelligible languages spoken by small, often village-scale political units rather than large confederacies, including the Chumash of the central and southern coast, the Pomo, Miwok, Maidu, Patwin, and Wintu of the north-central valleys and coast ranges, and the Yurok, Karuk, and Hupa of the northwest.

Despite this extraordinary linguistic diversity, a shared ceremonial and cosmological vocabulary runs across much of central and northern California, most visibly in the Kuksu religious complex described below, while southern coastal groups such as the Chumash developed their own distinct, highly elaborated cosmology centered on a three-tiered universe and a hereditary society of ritual and astronomical specialists.

Origins and Cosmology

Chumash cosmology describes a universe of three primary worlds: an Upper World (Mishupashup), home to powerful sky deities and supported on the back of the golden eagle Slo'w; the Middle World (Itiashup), the human realm centered symbolically on Mount Piños; and a dangerous Lower World (C'oyinashup) inhabited by monstrous beings called the nunashush. Kakunupmawa, the Sun, described as the radiance of the child born at the winter solstice, is understood to witness all human affairs, while Sky Coyote (Shnilemun) is a powerful and influential sky being whose relationship with the Sun structures much of Chumash ceremonial astronomy; the Morning Star is generally benevolent, in explicit contrast to a more dangerous Evening Star.

Across the Kuksu-practicing nations further north and inland — the Patwin, Maidu, Pomo, Miwok, Ohlone (Costanoan), Salinan, and Yokuts — cosmology centers less on a fixed pantheon than on the maintenance of a fragile natural balance, achieved and renewed through the secret-society ceremonial system described below.

The Kuksu Religion — Secret Societies and World Renewal

The Kuksu religious complex, practiced across a wide swath of central and northern California from the Sacramento Valley to the Pacific coast, centers on male ceremonial societies whose initiated members met in semi-subterranean roundhouses and performed masked, costumed dances at public ceremonies believed to promote health, fertility, successful harvests and hunts, and favorable weather — in effect, an annual renewal of the world's proper functioning.

Among the Pomo, a costumed dancer representing Kuksu — frequently a medicine practitioner — appeared briefly at most major ceremonies specifically to draw illness away from community members, a direct healing function layered onto the broader renewal purpose of the ceremonial cycle. Among the Patwin and Maidu, the Hesi ceremony represents an important variant of Kuksu practice that, unlike the core secret-society rites, included female participants, and annual mourning ceremonies and rites of passage rounded out the yearly ceremonial calendar in most Kuksu-practicing communities. Archaeological evidence of underground dance chambers and wooden foot-drums across the region confirms the deep antiquity of this ceremonial architecture.

Sacred Basketry and the Acorn Harvest

Basket weaving across California nations is at once a practical craft, a fine art, and a spiritual discipline, with specific techniques, materials, and even individual baskets carrying ceremonial significance — some woven so tightly they hold water, others made specifically as gifts, grave goods, or ceremonial regalia rather than for daily use. Basketry knowledge is transmitted through careful apprenticeship, typically along family lines, and is inseparable from a broader traditional ecological knowledge system, including the deliberate, controlled use of fire to cultivate the specific plant materials — sedge, redbud, willow — that fine basketry requires.

The acorn, gathered and processed (through leaching to remove bitter tannins) as the dietary staple across most of central California, is harvested and prepared according to seasonal protocols that in many communities include explicit first-fruits acknowledgment before the season's general harvest begins, echoing the same theological logic found in the Green Corn and First Salmon rites of other regions: the first food of the season is offered or acknowledged before the community eats freely of it.

Key Figures — Ishi and the Weight of Witness

Ishi, the last known member of the Yahi people (a Yana-speaking group of the southern Cascade foothills), emerged alone from hiding near Oroville, California, in 1911, after decades of violent settler attacks had killed or displaced the rest of his community; he spent the remaining five years of his life living at the University of California's Museum of Anthropology under the care and study of anthropologist Alfred Kroeber, becoming, against his will, the most publicly recognized symbol of California's Indigenous devastation.

The Kroeber-Ishi relationship remains a genuinely contested subject: Kroeber and his colleagues documented irreplaceable Yahi language, technology, and cultural knowledge directly from Ishi, and by most contemporary accounts treated him with real personal warmth, yet the relationship also exemplifies the extractive, often consent-bypassing anthropological practice of the era, including the post-mortem retention of Ishi's brain by the Smithsonian Institution for decades before its eventual repatriation and reburial in 2000 — a fact that has substantially reshaped how Ishi's story is now taught and discussed.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Basket weaving itself functions for many contemporary California Native weavers as a meditative and spiritually restorative practice, explicitly discussed within revival programs as a form of cultural and personal healing as much as artistic production, particularly for communities working to recover knowledge disrupted by mission-era suppression and subsequent violence.

Cultural burning — the deliberate, small-scale, seasonal use of fire to manage landscape health, encourage useful plant growth, and reduce catastrophic wildfire risk — is both a practical land-management technology and a spiritual practice bound up with reciprocal obligation to the land, and has seen a significant revival and increasing formal partnership with state and federal land agencies in California over the past two decades as its ecological value has become more widely recognized outside Native communities.

Traditional healing practices among California nations historically combined herbal medicine, often gender-specific ritual knowledge (particularly among women healers), and ceremonial practice performed by trained specialists, in a framework that, as elsewhere in Indigenous North America, treated physical illness as inseparable from spiritual and social imbalance.

The 'Antap Society and Sacred Astronomy

Among the Chumash, the 'antap society — a selective, hereditary body of ritual and astronomical specialists centered historically near Mount Piños — preserved and controlled access to core cosmological knowledge, including the observation and ceremonial marking of solstices and other astronomical events central to Chumash religious life. Cave and rock-shelter paintings found throughout Chumash territory, created and interpreted by 'antap members, are understood by contemporary scholars and Chumash descendants alike to encode this astronomical and cosmological knowledge — depicting mythic figures, celestial phenomena, and their understood effects on the human world — rather than functioning as simple decorative or narrative art.

This knowledge system survived the disruption of coastal Chumash village life under the Spanish mission system in part because the 'antap society's core teachings were maintained by inland and mountain communities less directly under mission control, allowing significant continuity of astronomical and cosmological knowledge into the present.

Legacy and Influence

In November 2024, the U.S. National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration formally designated the Chumash Heritage National Marine Sanctuary, protecting 4,543 square miles of central California coastal waters — the third-largest marine sanctuary in the United States, the first sanctuary ever nominated by an Indigenous nation, and the first new national marine sanctuary designated in over three decades. The Northern Chumash Tribal Council now formally co-stewards the sanctuary alongside NOAA and the State of California, marking, according to tribal chairwoman Violet Sage Walker, a historic first for Indigenous-led ocean governance in the United States and a formal recognition of the Pacific as 'Grandmother Ocean,' honoring roughly twenty thousand years of documented Chumash coastal occupation.

California basketry, particularly Pomo and Chumash work, is recognized internationally as among the finest basketry traditions in the world, held in major museum collections and actively taught in tribal cultural revival programs; the growing formal adoption of Indigenous cultural burning practice by California state and federal fire agencies represents a rare, substantive instance of traditional ecological knowledge directly reshaping mainstream public land policy.

Genocide and Reckoning — Controversies and Fairness

California's Indigenous population is estimated to have fallen by roughly eighty percent between 1846 and 1873, principally due to a documented, in significant part state-sanctioned, campaign of violence against Native communities during and after the Gold Rush, including militia expeditions explicitly funded by the state legislature and, in some documented cases, bounties paid for Native scalps or heads — a episode increasingly and explicitly described by contemporary historians as genocide rather than incidental frontier violence.

In June 2019, California Governor Gavin Newsom issued a formal state apology for this history, using the word 'genocide' explicitly, and established a Truth and Healing Council tasked with documenting this history and its ongoing effects and advising the state on further steps toward accountability; the apology and council were broadly welcomed by California tribal leaders while also drawing criticism, from some Native commentators and scholars, that formal acknowledgment has not yet been matched by proportionate material action on land return, funding, or federal recognition for California nations still lacking it. The scholarly and public reassessment of the Ishi-Kroeber relationship described above forms part of this same broader, still-unfolding reckoning with how California's Indigenous history has been told and by whom.

Closing

Ishi's name is still, a century later, the name most Americans associate with California's Indigenous history — a fact that says as much about the scale of the loss as it does about the man himself.

But the roundhouses are still built, the baskets are still woven, and as of November 2024 the Chumash co-steward, for the first time in American history, the ocean they have always called Grandmother.

Grand rising to the peoples of the basket world — the water is being looked after again by the people who first called it kin.